

## Readings

### Money and the Spirit – Dan Hotchkiss

Money is a spiritual challenge. It arouses great depths of passion in us and requires the best of us in moral reasoning and courage. Money is a medium of power through which we act and are acted upon. A spiritual life that does not concern itself with money can have little effect on our daily lives, especially in a culture as saturated by financial forces as ours....

What does it mean to have a spiritually mature relationship with money? One thing it means, certainly, is to face facts rather than denying or distorting them. Spiritual maturity also means taking account of reality in all its paradox and ambiguity, rather than resorting to quick doctrinal fixes. Decisions making about money do not lend itself to pat ethical formulas. Short of renouncing money for a life of poverty, we cannot escape the need to balance multiple, sometimes conflicting values. Generosity, as good as it is, stands in tension with our other obligations – to care for our families, to take responsibility for ourselves, to deal fairly with others in the marketplace. No doubt most of us could and should be more generous than we are. At the same time, though, we could invest more of our money in constructive business ventures, provide more adequately for our retirement, and care better for our dependents – which may or may not involve providing more money for them. A spiritually mature person balances competing values, not for the sake of compromise, but to 'hold fast to what is good' even when ends refuse to meet."

### So Long and Thanks for All the Fish - Douglas Adams.

This planet (earth) has – or rather, had – a problem, which was this: most of the people living on it were unhappy for pretty much of the time. Many solutions were suggestions for this problem, but most of these were largely concerned with the movements of small pieces of paper, which is odd because on the whole, it wasn't the small green pieces of paper that were unhappy.

## **How Much is That Nice Church In the Window?**

In their effort to save money, I don't think they realized how truly insulting their suggestion is. And this same suggestion has been presented to me at almost every facility where I have worked. Administration will come to me trying to figure out how to provide spiritual care coverage during off hours for the patients or residents. The idea they present is that we have local clergy supply emergency spiritual care and regular religious service on evenings, weekends, and holidays. It is assumed that they will do this for free.

I do my best to respond graciously, while offering some education. A pastor and a chaplain are not the same thing and to assume that someone with no special training could walk in and do my job tells me how little administration knows about what I do. It also tells me that they believe ministers have lots of free time and are looking for ways to serve beyond their church. I usually ask administration if they are also asking local social workers to come in and provide emergency Social Services for our people with no compensation. They always look at me funny and say with some indignation, "That's not the same thing!"

Somehow, it is so embedded in our Western culture that religion shouldn't have anything to do with money, that even introducing the notion of payment for professional services does not register. Advocating that the ministers should be paid fairly arouses images of greed and raises questions concerning their fitness for God's service.

In the same vein, some people become incensed when they talk about how churches are always asking for money. For many, it is all the evidence they need to prove that religion is hypocritical. You won't catch them spending their time, or giving their money, to such a two-faced organization!

Here's the rub – our western culture does not like the idea of combining organized religion and money. In many ways, poverty is the litmus test of sincerity. We can trust that poor ministers and simple churches aren't in it for the big bucks. And I concede we would be foolish not to have some questions regarding wealthy ministers and over the top churches given all the sleazy televangelist scandals. However, it is interesting to note that while most people feel better keeping religion

separate from filthy lucre, there is also a long held conception that God has blessed the rich.

Just a bit of quick and simplified theology here. In early Jewish theology, money was seen as good, a gift from God, and those who were blessed with abundance were expected to use it to help care for the less fortunate. The Jewish temple was financed through offerings, many of which were largely prescribed fees. The people were expected to all help pay for the temple's upkeep. Money and religion were part of everyday life. And this was common in most ancient civilizations. Religion was woven through daily life. The people paid offerings, allowing some to be designated priests, and all citizens were expected to help finance the temple. As a matter of fact, temples were the first banks. Temple comes from the words for "treasure house." When civilizations started using money rather than bartering systems, the temples were the safest place to store anything one didn't want at home or on their person. The priests were the educated ones who could write and keep track of individuals' financial records. Most religions had rules about money and laid down the acceptable practices regarding interests and loans. Plus, there was the added bonus that thieves were less likely to steal money kept at a temple, since it might incur the wrath of the gods.

Things started to change about the time of the New Testament and the tremendous influence of Greek philosophy. The mis-use of money begins to remove it from its holy, or at least neutral status, into something unclean. Jesus drives the money changers from the temple, not because what they were doing was wrong. People came to the Jewish temple from all over the world and needed their currency changed into the correct coin so they could pay the temple tax. But the money changers' service morphed into a disproportionately lucrative enterprise. Jesus was angry that people were being sorely taken advantage of in the name of religion. And it wasn't like they could go to a competing coin changer to get a better price. They were over a barrel. In addition, the whole issue of Jews paying taxes to their Roman occupiers was a painful and dangerous topic.

Greek philosophers, beginning famously with Plato, became enamored with the idea of dualism. The spirit and anything of the spirit was superior to anything of the earth. This thinking begins to show up in early Christian writing. In the Torah, God had made humans in the image of God, whole beings that were good. Dualism separated the spirit and the body.

Theologians reinforced this philosophy. The spirit is good, the body is bad. This leads to all sorts of unfortunate consequences: the human body must be subjugated, all appetites must be controlled, sex becomes dirty, women are debased as temptresses, violence against the earth and anything associated with the lower nature is condoned. Money, or at least the love of money, is the root of evil. Men are associated with logic, the mind, and strength. They are viewed as superior to women who are seen as soft, emotional, and weak. Dualism is not about acknowledging and honoring difference. It pits one side of the coin against the other. Black and white thinking becomes is regarded as the truth.

Making a very long history short, today we are left with a lot of emotional and theological confusion about money. Money and religion are distrusted. Yet it is easy to believe that if one sacrifices enough, gives enough money and offerings, God, or the gods, will come through and provide rain, or healing, or a child. At the same time, spirituality and money become unfortunately linked. There are teachers everywhere who will show you how to become rich, live abundantly, and attract wealth if you just follow their instructions. Often these teachings come with a steep fee.

On one hand, people understand the need to pay dues to be members in professional organizations, county clubs, and civic groups. Folks understand the need for pledge drives and donations requests for non-profits. If we want a particular service or product, we pay. If we want to belong to various groups, we submit our dues. If we like what someone is doing and want to support the effort, even if we don't personally benefit, we donate. This all makes sense to us and as adults we know that nothing is ever really free.

And still, we somehow believe that different rules apply for religion. I remember hearing that some synagogues had set dues for their members. My immediate reaction was both "They can't do that!" and "What a great idea!"

Money and religion can be so messy! It gets especially tough when a local congregation or a church pastor starts to talk about it. While the Greek word "oikonomia" is the basis for our words "economics" and "ecology", we also know that when it is translated as "stewardship", it really means "here they come asking for money again."

As a guest minister, I truly want this congregation to do well financially. Since I am only a guest and we aren't talking about my salary or benefits, I

can offer a few thoughts about religion and money, and specifically Unitarian Universalism and money. I have four points I'd like to offer. Perhaps things won't be quite so messy.

First, money is very religious. Money is about value. What do we value, where do we place our energy, how do we measure our worth, what do we trust? Statistically, people who have experienced true scarcity are the most generous philanthropically. In an odd twist, those who have never known real shortage are more likely to judge their worth and security based on their possessions. It is harder to give when one's self-esteem is attached to what you have. There is a big difference between "being" and "having." Those who know they are not what they own are more confident in their generosity.

Our UU tradition was born out of the Protestant Christian beliefs. It is interesting to note that in the Bible, money and possessions are the biggest topic. 1 out of every 8 verses talks about the relationship between faith and how you use your money and possessions. Of the 10 commandments, 3 provide instruction on how you use your money and possessions. Of the 38 parables that Jesus tells, 16 deal with the relationship between what you say you believe and how you use your finances and assets. Of everything that Jesus talks about in the New Testament, the second biggest topic is the use of money and possessions. Love is the first. Given this ratio, most congregations hear far less from preachers meddling in their money and faith than they realize.

A Lilly Endowment funded study found that 70% of the dollars donated to non-religious philanthropic organizations comes from people who worship in a church or synagogue at least once a month. The American Heart Association, the Humane Society, Springboard for the Arts, NPR – we give to the organizations that are living out our values.

As a UU minister, I often wonder if our congregations understand what a difference it makes in a community to have a liberal, free church present. With all the good a UU congregation offers just by being here, we can feel very good about supporting those values.

Money touches on giving, worth, values, faith, trust, and gratitude. Money is religious.

The second point I'd like to mention is that congregational money is a community matter. People are most likely to give or pledge to their church because of their relationships. It is for this reason that the every-member

or selected canvas is the most effective way to help people give to the church. When they are personally asked, they are more likely to respond.

As a community, it is important to be transparent about money. Being up front about budgets and fees builds trust. The more open a congregation is about what people give, making sure to provide complete and easy to read financial reports, the more likely that church is to generate the level of support they need. This also includes being honest about where the congregation's money comes from. This doesn't mean that everyone's pledge is posted on the church door like Luther's 95 thesis. However, it is not necessarily a bad thing for the pastor and the board to know how much people contribute to the church. This can prevent wasted emotional energy. When one learns that those who complain the most, and the loudest are often those giving the least money, least time, least energy and don't contribute much on any level, it becomes easier not to invest so much emotional energy into people who aren't really that invested in the church.

When there are new members, as a community, help them understand how to be a part of the congregation financially. We get so weird about talking about money, that often people really don't know how to give or how much to give. Some guidance is usually helpful. More on that later.

Point three, money is about the mission. Some people are very vocal, claiming "All the congregation ever does is ask for money!" Well first, let me remind you of all the other non-profits to whom you donate. Aren't they always asking for money? How many PBS pledge drives do we have a year? How many special calendars, tote bags, personalized address labels, and T-shirts are we offered each month if we would just donate to this or that special cause?

What if, instead of apologizing for asking for money, we claimed the value and importance of what we do? We don't want your money for electric bills and office supplies and building maintenance. We want your money because we have a mission! We will keep asking for money until every person is treated with dignity and respect. We will keep asking for money until we see a world where there is justice, equity and compassion in human relations! We will keep asking for money until every community can operate from the right of conscience and the use of democratic process. We will keep asking for money until the whole world, the full interdependent web of which we are a part, is treated with care and respect. We will keep

asking for money until every person has the opportunity to engage in the free and responsible search for truth and meaning.

We have a mission. That's why we ask for money. This is what we support and what we are about. Help people to understand what this congregation is about and its unique mission. Then invite them to help finance it. And please, don't offer them a "free" tote bag when they give.

And finally, my fourth point, how much should we give? It is easier in some of the more evangelical churches. Members are instructed to tithe 10% to the church. The only question really becomes, does one tithe on their gross or net income. But most main line churches don't have such a clear directive. The UUA does have some guidelines. I'm not going to recite those here today. Instead, I prefer the suggestion, "Give until it feels great." The most important thing about giving to your congregation isn't what it does for the congregation. It is about what giving does for you. When we are at our best, we give. It is something that humans do. Good giving makes us feel more authentic and alive. So, if your pledge doesn't feel satisfying, try giving more. Give until it feels really, really good.

The Stewardship campaign or annual pledge drive is not really about how the church can get money from you. It is an invitation to explore what it is that you value, where you get your worth, and what is important to you. Then you are called to experiment with how you are going to live out what you truly value in the real world. When our beliefs, values, and actions line up, we feel more alive and life feels more abundant.

Perhaps the next time you hear that religion is asking for money, you won't be offended. Any dichotomy between good religion and bad money is false. Religion is intimately tied to what we do with our money and possessions. We can be open and honest about giving. There is no shame in talking about money or in educating our new members about the obligations and the rewards of this community. Maybe, it isn't too farfetched to get a little excited about financially supporting the mission of your church. These are values worth supporting, at least as much as the humane treatment of animals and decent television programming. And finally, give so that it feels great. Let it bless you, not diminish you. Good giving is never a sacrifice.

My desire for you, as a congregation, and as individuals, is that you take on the very messy and complicated matter of money and what it really means in relationship to your lived faith. And, I hope that the next time the

"Stewardship Campaign" comes around, you are able to think about it differently. It is just possible that this whole campaign is really about how to best live out our UU mission in our communities and our world. And if not, you can always ask for your money back!

Amen and Amen.